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GOOD TIMES Uddhav Thackeray with son Aaditya and wife Rashmi at a Shiv Sena event shortly after he took over as CM in Nov. 2019

and Raut insisted the extra 10 votes be allocated to Congress candidates as an act of goodwill towards an ally. "Why are you trying to strengthen the Congress? Our focus should be on securing our position," a source quotes Shinde saying. He was only being extra cautious—on June 11, Sena candidate Sanjay Pawar had lost the Rajya Sabha election because the party could not manage the requisite votes. Padvi and Ahir emerged victorious on June 20, but it soon became clear that three Sena MLAs and six associates had cross-voted for the BJP.

THE SHINDE SHINDIG

An upset Shinde reached the Mayor's bungalow in his suburban hometown Thane in the evening, even before the last results were out. Everyone knew the beautiful five-acre complex—sprawled at the feet of the Yeoor Hills, on the banks of the scenic Upavan Lake—was Shinde's favourite spot for schmoozing and conferring with political friends. This time, he called over 23 Sena MLAs, dined with them...and dispatched them to Surat in two mini-buses in batches of 11 and 12 respectively. Thane, the bustling city that takes off where Mumbai ends, was the place that had given the Sena its first big electoral success back in 1987, when Satish Pradhan was elected mayor. Indeed, the legend in Marathi—'*Shiv Seneche Thane, Thanyachi Shiv Sena*'—explicitly spoke of this mutual sense of belonging. And now, one of its key actors had effected the biggest ever coup in the Sena from the same city.

The taciturn, action-oriented Shinde had been initiated into politics by the late Anand Dighe, once the second-most powerful party leader after Bal Thackeray. A native of Dare in Satara district, Shinde worked as a supervisor in a chemical company and drove an autorickshaw to supplement his income to feed a family of six at that point. Under Dighe's mentorship, his graph rose in sure and swift strokes—ultimately being elected as a Thane councillor in 1997. Dighe's death in 2001 didn't thwart Shinde's rise or his entrenchment in the Thane landscape. In 2004, he was chosen as the Sena candidate from the Kopri-Pachpakhadi assembly seat within Thane, and he has represented the constituency since then. By 2014, he became a force to reckon with in Thane and Palghar districts, which collectively have 24 assembly constituencies. His fortunes saw a decisive upswing after Uddhav joined the BJP government under Devendra Fadnavis in December 2014—a moment that marked the Sena's return to power after 15 years. Shinde's own career had been forged during that hiatus, but now he was made minister for public works (public undertakings)—a portfolio that brought key infrastructure projects, such as the metro, highways, flyovers and bridges, under his charge.

Here, he prospered in the complex field of alliance politics as well as politics connected to the grassroots. Fadnavis's decision to build a super expressway between his hometown Nagpur and Mumbai proved a vital turning point. Uddhav expressed stiff opposition to the project—later renamed 'Samruddhi Mahamarg'—arguing it would be disastrous for farmers who would have to give away fertile farmlands. Fadnavis roped in Shinde to convince Uddhav. It worked. Shinde not only persuaded Uddhav, he even got him to describe the expressway as a game-changer. Next, Shinde ensured that compensation was transferred online to farmers' accounts instantly—that softened the opposition from the ground too. The expressway thus inaugurated a bridge of close friendship between Fadnavis and Shinde as well.

Shinde was only beginning to demonstrate his capacity for productive public outreach. During the 2018 Kerala floods, he reached the waterlogged state with boxes of medicines and first-aid tools. That imparted another creative turn to his politics. Returning to Mumbai after a fortnight, he floated a medical services cell, the 'Balasaheb Thackeray Shiv Sena Vaidyakeey Madat Kaksh', which soon set up active branches in all of Maharashtra's 36 districts. Just 18 months after Kerala, as the Covid-19 pandemic broke on the megapolis, this parallel structure went on to play saviour to thousands. Shinde's team was faster and prompter than the government machinery in helping the needy, especially in rural areas, with medicines and hospital beds. With an infirm Uddhav forced into confinement at home, the contrast couldn't have been starker. Shinde was among the few ministers who visited hospitals regularly and proactively helped in crisis management—burnishing the good samaritan image he had been cultivating, and parlaying that off creatively into